Listening answer rules: spelling, plurals and numbers

Understand it

Many Listening points are lost not because the answer was missed but because it was written wrongly: too many words, a missing plural, a spelling error. On the computer test you type your answers, so typing accuracy matters too.

Read the instruction for every question set and obey it exactly.

The rules

- Follow the word limit exactly: NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS means 1 or 2 words. A number counts as a word. Hyphenated words count as one.
- Write exactly what you hear; plurals matter: if the audio says 'boxes', write boxes.
- Numbers and dates: 15 or fifteen both fine; dates like 3rd March or March 3 are accepted. Spell names carefully.
- Spelling: use one spelling consistently. Capital letters are fine for answers; commonly missed words: accommodation, necessary, environment, government.

All the words and forms you need

Word limits	ONE WORD ONLY · NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS · ONE WORD AND/OR A NUMBER · NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER
What counts as one word	a number (15) · a hyphenated word (well-known) · a date can be one or more words
Numbers	15 or fifteen · £20 · 7.30 · 3rd of March / March 3 · 1990s · 2,500
Often misspelled	accommodation · necessary · environment · government · library · temperature · equipment · Wednesday · February · questionnaire
Plurals	write the -s if you hear it · irregular: children · women · people · feet
Capitals	allowed in all answers: you may type everything in capitals

Where you use it

Listening: One wrong letter loses the mark: check spelling in the last minute.

Reading: The same word-limit rules apply to completion questions.

Writing: Spelling counts in the vocabulary score.

Speaking: Not applicable.

More examples

- Instruction: NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS. Answer: 'library card' ✓ 'a library card' ✗

- Audio: 'the twenty-fifth of May' → 25 May ✓
- Audio: 'two bedrooms' → bedrooms ✓ bedroom ✗
- Audio: 'It's spelled K-E-N-D-A-L-L' → Kendall ✓

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ Writing three words for NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS.	✓ Use at most two words.
✗ Writing a plural as singular.	✓ Match the audio.
✗ accomodation	✓ accommodation

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. Spell your name and your street aloud.
2. Say these numbers: 15, 50, 1,250, 0.5, 2007.
3. Say today's date in two ways.

Writing practice

Dictation: ask someone to read 10 numbers and 10 names; write them and check.

Practice

1. Word limit: ONE WORD AND/OR A NUMBER. Is 'pink flowers' correct?

   _____

2. Is 'twenty-five' one or two words?

   _____

3. Spell: the place where you live (a long word)

   _____

4. Spell: what you need to pass

   _____

5. The audio says boxes. Write:

   _____

6. Is 15th May a correct date answer?

   _____

Answers

1. No
2. One (hyphenated)
3. accommodation
4. necessary
5. boxes
6. Yes